The Hindu
EDITORIAL ANALYSIS

18th January 2025

PREPARE FOR BANK (PO/ CLERK), SSC,UPSC, State PSC, CAT,CTET,RAILWAY EXAMS,CDS, TET, NDA/AIRFORCE, NET and all Govt. Exams

VOCABULARY

1. Resurged (फिर से उभरा)

Meaning: To rise or grow again after a period of decline.
Synonyms: Reemerged, rebounded, recovered
Antonyms: Declined, subsided, dwindled
Example: The stock market resurged after weeks of poor performance.

2. Imponderables (अनिश्चित)

Meaning: Factors or aspects that cannot be precisely estimated or understood.
Synonyms: Uncertainties, variables, unknowns
Antonyms: Certainties, constants, definites
Example: The imponderables of the global market made it difficult to predict future trends.

VOCABULARY

3. Deciphering (डिकोड करना)

Meaning: To interpret or make sense of something that is difficult to understand.
Synonyms: Decoding, interpreting, solving
Antonyms: Obscuring, encrypting, complicating
Example: Scientists are working on deciphering the ancient texts of the Indus Valley Civilisation.

4. Nuanced (सूक्ष्म अंतर वाला)

Meaning: Characterized by subtle and complex distinctions or variations.
Synonyms: Subtle, refined, intricate
Antonyms: Obvious, blunt, straightforward
Example: The issue requires a nuanced approach to resolve conflicting interests.

VOCABULARY

5. Unraveling (सुलझाना)

Meaning: To investigate or solve something complicated, or to untangle.
Synonyms: Solving, deciphering, untangling
Antonyms: Confusing, complicating, entangling
Example: The team is working hard on unraveling the mysteries of the ancient civilisation.

6. Pursuit (अनुसरण)

Meaning: The action of following or chasing something; an activity or goal being followed.
Synonyms: Chase, search, quest
Antonyms: Retreat, withdrawal, surrender
Example: The pursuit of knowledge is a never-ending journey for many scholars.

VOCABULARY

7. Fading (घटता हुआ)

Meaning: Becoming weaker, less intense, or disappearing gradually.
Synonyms: Diminishing, declining, withering
Antonyms: Strengthening, increasing, intensifying
Example: As the day went on, the sound of the music was fading into the background.

8. Glide (फिसलना)

Meaning: To move smoothly or continuously in a specific direction.
Synonyms: Slide, float, drift
Antonyms: Stumble, stop, hinder
Example: The bird glided gracefully across the sky.

VOCABULARY

9. Concede (स्वीकार करना)

Meaning: Admit that something is true or valid after first denying or resisting it.
Synonyms: Admit, acknowledge, accept
Antonyms: Deny, dispute, contradict
Example: The company had to concede that the product was faulty after numerous complaints.

10. Avert (टालना)

Meaning: To prevent or ward off an undesirable occurrence.
Synonyms: Prevent, avoid, forestall
Antonyms: Cause, allow, encourage
Example: The timely intervention helped avert a major disaster.

VOCABULARY

Phrasal Verbs:

1. Wrap up
Meaning: To finish or complete something.

2. Run into
Meaning: To meet by accident or unexpectedly

3. Map out
Meaning: To plan or design something in detail.

4. Drop off
Meaning: To decrease or decline; to deliver someone or something at a specific location.

VOCABULARY

Idioms & Phrases

1. On a roll like a runaway wheel

Meaning: Experiencing continuous success or momentum.

2. Roll in the dough

Meaning: Be very wealthy or make a lot of money.

3. State of the art

Meaning: The most advanced or sophisticated level of technology or design.

VOCABULARY

4. A bunch of baloney

Meaning: Nonsense or something not true.

5. Off the top of my head

Meaning: Saying something without much thought or preparation.

Article for Reading

Inflation matrix: on the numbers and trends

In the final inflation print before the Union Budget for 2025-26 is presented, followed by the first review of the monetary policy led by the new Governor of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) in early February, the price rise faced by Indian consumers eased to 5.22% in December. Although a four-month low, this still marked only a mild decline from November's 5.5% uptick in the Consumer Price Index (CPI), and was largely driven by a sequential easing in food prices. Food inflation moderated from over 9% in the previous month to 8.4% last month, and though inflation in vegetables cooled from 29.3% to 26.6%, it still remained generally high. Households still forked out a lot more for their meals than they did a year ago — it must be recalled that overall inflation was 5.7% and food price rise, over 9.5% in December 2023.

While prices of some food items, including vegetables, are seen cooling further this month, those of a few critical ingredients have started spiking, including of edible oils, that rose at a 33-month high pace of 14.6% in December. Eggs, meat and fruits also saw inflation accelerating last month along with the relatively humble potato (up 68.2%). Moreover, inflation in wholesale prices has gained pace, signalling that there is room for higher costs to be passed on to consumers for food items as well as manufactured products. The government and industry want the RBI to cut interest rates to reinvigorate consumption and fading growth impulses by looking through 'volatile' food inflation. But even industry captains admit that just keeping food prices out of the interest rates and growth-inflation balancing act will not suffice. Moreover, even if the weightage for food in the CPI is reduced in line with the recent household consumption spending survey results, food price trends have a material impact on the spending propensity of households and their inflation expectations.

Inflation may yet average 4.5% through January to March, as the RBI expects, but the central bank that has committed to await a durable alignment to its 4% goal before slashing rates, has a difficult call to make in February. Tangible measures, if any, to ease price pressures in the Budget, along with some visibility on the Centre's fiscal glide path, could help tip the scales for a rate cut cycle to begin soon, if not next month. There are a few new imponderables that have compounded the trade-off matrix for policymakers in North Block as well as Mint Street — the swift unravelling of the rupee vis-à-vis the dollar in recent weeks which raises the risk of importing inflation, among other collateral effects, especially as global oil prices have resurged to multi-month highs. A very nuanced approach is imperative to avoid fresh missteps.

Summary

In December 2024, India's inflation eased to 5.22%, a four-month low, driven by a decline in food prices. However, food inflation remains high at 8.4%, with significant spikes in specific items like edible oils (14.6%) and potatoes (68.2%). While food prices may cool further, wholesale price inflation has risen, suggesting more cost pressures. As the Union Budget and the RBI's first monetary policy review under the new Governor approach, policymakers face a dilemma. The government and industry seek interest rate cuts to boost growth, but high inflation, rupee depreciation, and global oil price surges complicate decisions. A balanced approach is crucial to avoid missteps, with hopes pinned on the Budget to ease price pressures and clarify fiscal plans.

The tone of the passage is analytical and cautious, reflecting a critical assessment of inflation trends, economic challenges, and the complexities facing policymakers.

Reading Comprehension

Based on the above passage, answer the following questions:

Question 1:
What is the RBI's stance on interest rate cuts as mentioned in the passage?

a) The RBI is likely to cut rates in the February review.
b) The RBI is awaiting a durable alignment to its 4% inflation target before cutting rates.
c) The RBI has ruled out any rate cuts in 2025.
d) The RBI is focusing solely on growth and not on inflation control.
e) None of the above

Question 2:
What factors complicate the decision-making for policymakers in India?

a) Declining wholesale prices and stable oil prices.
b) Strengthening of the rupee and rising food inflation.
c) Global oil price resurgence and a weakening rupee.
d) Decreased demand for exports and lower tax revenues.
e) None of the above

Article for Skimming

Script reading: on deciphering the script of the Indus Valley Civilisation

The recent announcement by Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin, of a $1-million prize scheme for deciphering the script of the Indus Valley Civilisation (IVC), seems to have revived popular interest in the subject, which remains a puzzle to archaeologists, historians and linguists. His invitation for further research was made in the context of the centenary celebration of the IVC discovery, which was published by then chief of the Archaeological Survey of India, John Marshall, in September 1924. Spread across 1.5 million square kilometres in the territories of modern-day India, Pakistan, and Afghanistan during the Bronze Age (3000-1500 BCE), the IVC, also known as Harappan Civilisation, was regarded as complex as the better-known civilisations of Mesopotamia, Egypt and China. The Indus civilisation was essentially urban. Even though there has been a large number of objects and materials of archaeological value in support of the IVC, the decipherment of seals and tablets has not been to the satisfaction of all.

About 20 years ago, a group of western scholars had argued that writing was not a necessity of ancient urban settlements, not even those as massive as those of the Harappans, and that “a handful of unknown symbols” could no longer be claimed as evidence of writing. Since then, there has been an exchange of scholarly views for and against the theory of the Indus civilisation being a highly literate society. It is against this context that Mr. Stalin’s announcement needs to be seen. There is also a school of thought that there was a script which was “proto-Dravidian”, “non-Aryan” and “pre-Aryan”. This could be a reason why a southern State, Tamil Nadu, has made the offer. The State government has also supported a study on Indus signs and graffiti marks of Tamil Nadu as part of a project of the documentation and the digitisation of graffiti and Tamili (Tamil-Brāhmī)-inscribed potsherds of Tamil Nadu. Researchers face certain challenges while resolving the Indus riddle.

There is a complaint that the entire database regarding the seals has not yet been made available in the public domain. While allowing free access to these resources, central and State authorities should ensure that context for them is also provided. More importantly, studies should be carried out without any interference. The likelihood of the proposed study's findings going against the established and particular narrative should not be allowed to cloud intellectual pursuit. There is also scope for well-coordinated work among South Asian countries, including Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Pakistan and Afghanistan, to unravel the mystery. But if political differences are permitted to adversely impact the execution of any such study, the world, and India, will be much the poorer for it.

Question 3:
What challenge hinders researchers from effectively studying the IVC seals?

a) The lack of advanced technology for decoding ancient scripts.
b) The absence of seals with inscriptions.
c) Linguistic barriers among South Asian countries.
d) The unavailability of the complete database in the public domain.
e) None of the above

Question 4:
What does the passage suggest to ensure the success of studies on the IVC script?

a) Assigning all research to global academic institutions.
b) Conducting studies free from interference and preconceived narratives.
c) Restricting collaboration to Indian researchers.
d) Focusing only on archaeological evidence from Tamil Nadu.
e) None of the above

Question 5
Why is international collaboration critical for deciphering the IVC script?

a) It ensures access to the latest technological tools for research.
b) It reduces the financial burden on any single country.
c) The IVC spanned multiple modern-day South Asian countries.
d) Political differences among nations have already been resolved.
e) None of the above

Today's Descriptive Question:

Precis Writing.

Original Text

The term "Silver Economy" refers to the economic opportunities associated with the aging population. As life expectancy increases and birth rates decline, many countries face a demographic shift toward an older population. This trend presents both challenges and opportunities for governments, businesses, and society at large. The silver economy is fueled by the purchasing power and specific needs of older adults, including healthcare, assistive technologies, housing, travel, and financial services. Globally, the spending power of the elderly is expected to grow, driving innovation in products and services tailored to their requirements.

For instance, advancements in telemedicine, age-friendly smart homes, and recreational activities are increasingly becoming popular among senior citizens. From a policy perspective, nations are focusing on creating inclusive environments that enable older individuals to remain active participants in society. Initiatives such as lifelong learning programs, senior employment policies, and social engagement activities aim to harness the potential of this demographic while improving their quality of life. Additionally, intergenerational collaboration—where younger and older generations share skills and resources—can foster a more harmonious society. However, challenges such as increased healthcare costs, pension sustainability, and social isolation among the elderly persist. Governments must strike a balance between leveraging the silver economy and addressing these issues to ensure equitable and inclusive growth. As the silver economy continues to expand, it highlights the importance of treating aging not as a burden but as an opportunity to build a more inclusive, innovative, and sustainable global economy.

Precis:

The "Silver Economy" taps into the economic opportunities arising from an aging population. With growing life expectancy and declining birth rates, older adults significantly influence markets like healthcare, housing, and technology. Policies focusing on lifelong learning, senior employment, and social inclusion aim to harness their potential. However, challenges like rising healthcare costs and social isolation must be addressed. Viewing aging as an opportunity, the silver economy emphasizes innovation and inclusivity, transforming aging populations into valuable contributors to global growth.

- **You are the HR Manager of XYZ Pvt. Ltd. Write an email to a candidate, John Doe, informing him about his selection for the role of Marketing Executive and providing details of the joining process.**

To: …….@gmail.com

Subject: Congratulations on Your Selection as Marketing Executive

Dear John Doe,

I hope this email finds you well. I am delighted to inform you that you have been selected for the role of Marketing Executive at XYZ Pvt. Ltd. after an impressive performance during the interview process. Congratulations on this achievement!

We are excited to have you join our team and contribute to our organization's success. Below are the details of the joining process:

1. Joining Date: [Insert date, e.g., Monday, February 5, 2025]
2. Reporting Time: [Insert time, e.g., 10:00 AM]

3. Reporting Location: [Insert office address, e.g., XYZ Pvt. Ltd., 123 Business Avenue, City, State, ZIP]
4. Documents to Carry:

A copy of this email for reference
Valid government-issued ID proof (original and photocopy)
Academic and professional certificates (originals and photocopies)
Two passport-sized photographs
Bank account details for salary processing
5. Contact Person: [Insert name and contact information of HR representative]

On your first day, you will undergo an induction session to familiarize yourself with our company policies, team structure, and work culture.

Please confirm your acceptance of this offer and your availability to join on the specified date by replying to this email at your earliest convenience. If you have any questions or require further assistance, feel free to reach out to us.

We are thrilled to welcome you to the XYZ Pvt. Ltd. family and look forward to a successful journey together!

Best regards,
[Your Full Name]
HR Manager
XYZ Pvt. Ltd.

Match the column

1. On a roll like a runaway wheel	A. Be very wealthy diligently
2. Roll in the dough	B. Nonsense or something not true
3. State of the art	C. Saying something without much thought
4. A bunch of baloney	D. Experiencing continuous success
5. Off the top of my head	E. The most advanced technology

Answer:

1-d

2-a

3-e

4-b

5-c

Vocabulary

1. Resurged:
2. Imponderables:
3. Deciphering:
4. Nuanced:
5. Unraveling:
6. Pursuit:
7. Fading:
8. Glide:
9. Concede:
10. Avert:

Rc ans

1.

Ans: b

Explanation:

The RBI has committed to waiting for a "durable alignment to its 4% goal before slashing rates."

Reference:

“... the central bank that has committed to await a durable alignment to its 4% goal before slashing rates...”

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) The passage suggests that a rate cut might begin soon but not necessarily in February.
c) There’s no mention of rate cuts being ruled out entirely in 2025.
d) The RBI is balancing growth and inflation control, not focusing solely on growth.

2.

Ans: c

Explanation:

The passage mentions that rising global oil prices and the weakening rupee create challenges, including risks of imported inflation and other collateral effects.

Reference:

“... especially as global oil prices have resurged to multi-month highs.”

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) Wholesale prices are rising, not declining, and oil prices are increasing.
b) The rupee is weakening, not strengthening.
d) Export demand and tax revenues are not discussed in the passage.

3.

Ans: d

Explanation:

The passage explicitly mentions that researchers complain about the entire database of seals not being available publicly, which hampers their ability to study the IVC script comprehensively.

Reference:

“There is a complaint that the entire database regarding the seals has not yet been made available in the public domain.”

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) Technology is not cited as a limitation here.
b) Seals with inscriptions exist but remain undeciphered.
c) Linguistic barriers are not mentioned as a direct challenge in the passage.

4.

Ans: b

Explanation:

The passage stresses the importance of conducting research without interference and without letting preconceived narratives cloud intellectual pursuits.

Reference:

“Studies should be carried out without any interference. The likelihood of the proposed study’s findings going against the established and particular narrative should not be allowed to cloud intellectual pursuit.”

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) There is no suggestion to assign research solely to global institutions.
c) Collaboration among South Asian countries is encouraged, not restricted.
d) While Tamil Nadu’s contributions are highlighted, the focus is on the IVC as a whole.

5.

Ans: c

Explanation:

The passage emphasizes that the IVC covered regions in modern-day India, Pakistan, and Afghanistan, making collaboration among these countries critical for comprehensive research.

Reference:

“There is also scope for well-coordinated work among South Asian countries, including Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Pakistan and Afghanistan, to unravel the mystery.”

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) While technology may aid research, this is not the stated reason for collaboration.

b) Financial aspects are not discussed in this context.

d) The passage notes that political differences remain a potential obstacle.

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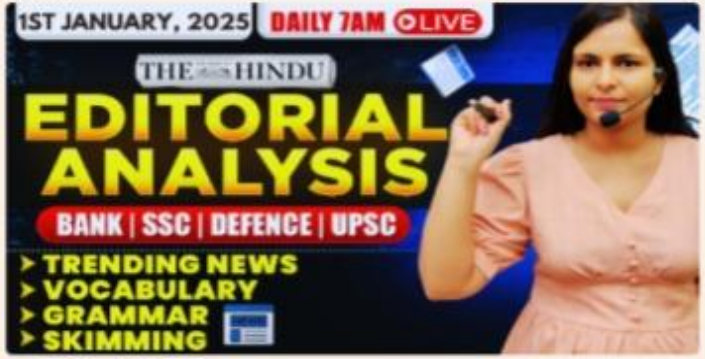

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